

Pros and Cons



In this section, we're exploring how to use Pros and Cons as a part of your Distress Tolerance practice. When you need to make a decision between two actions, you can write a pro and con list. Use the Pro and Con exercise to determine how to act in a crisis situation.

A DBT pro and con list is writing out the positive and negative consequences of both:

- tolerating distress by resisting impulsive behaviors AND
- not tolerating distress by engaging in these behaviors

So how should you get started on your pro and con list?

START BY DESCRIBING THE CRISIS BEHAVIOR

A crisis behavior is any behavior that is detrimental to your well-being in either the short or long term. Generally, people have an action urge when stress hits and often acting on that urge provides short term relief as the risk of long term happiness and well-being.

EXAMINE THE ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF ACTING ON THE BEHAVIOR AND RESISTING THE BEHAVIOR

It is important to look at the situation from all angles. The pros of resisting will not necessarily be the same as the cons of not resisting. Consider both the short term and long term consequences.

REHEARSE MULTIPLE TIMES

This helps ensure that these thoughts will pop into your mind when the urge hits. If you know a crisis situation may arise, read through your list. It's helpful to read the list at least once a day.

PULL OUT THE LIST WHEN THE URGE HITS

Put the list in places where you may be triggered or that you generally look at so it stays fresh in your mind. Write a pro and con list in the moment if a new urge hits to help you to not act impulsively.

Here's an example:

You participate in class and get upset by the teacher's feedback.

Options: tolerate distress and process/regulate when the time is right or yell back at the teacher and/or storm out of class.

	Pros	Cons
Acting on crisis urges	I would be able to continue to feel what I was used to feeling, which sometimes brings comfort I could experience a temporary satisfaction of having punished myself	My instructor might not let me come back to class or at least, there would be tension between us I would experience regret, pain, and shame the next day or maybe even right after acting out
Resisting crisis urges	Feeling of success that I was able to use my skills I might be able to change my state of mind and continue my life normally without using up my energy	I would have to put effort into self-control I wouldn't get that high feeling of creating drama and making others pay attention to me.